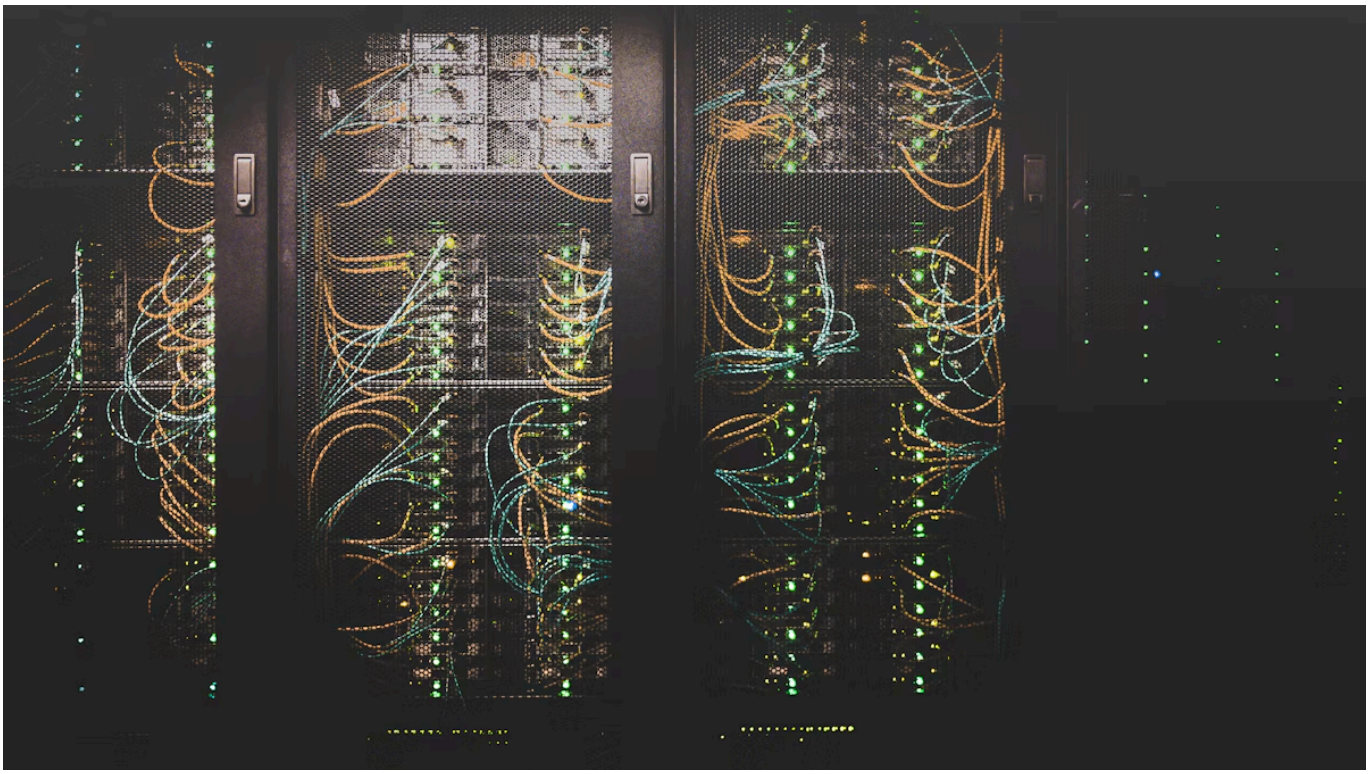
🌐 Computer Networks

A Beginner's Guide to How Devices Communicate

> **THE BIG IDEA**
>
> How does a message travel from your laptop to a friend on the other side of the world?
>
> Computer networks make this communication possible.



📚 Learning Objectives

By the end of this guide, you will be able to:

- Define a computer network and explain its purpose.
- Distinguish between LAN, WAN, wired, and wireless networks.
- Describe the roles of routers, switches, and network interfaces.
- Explain the difference between IP addresses and MAC addresses.
- Trace the basic journey of data from a laptop to a website.
- Identify several common network protocols.

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01 · Understanding Computer Networks

What is a computer network?

A **computer network** is a group of two or more connected devices that communicate and share information or resources.

These devices may include laptops, smartphones, printers, servers, and other network-enabled equipment.

Think about your daily life: when you connect your phone to Wi-Fi, send a message, or watch a video online, you are using computer networking.

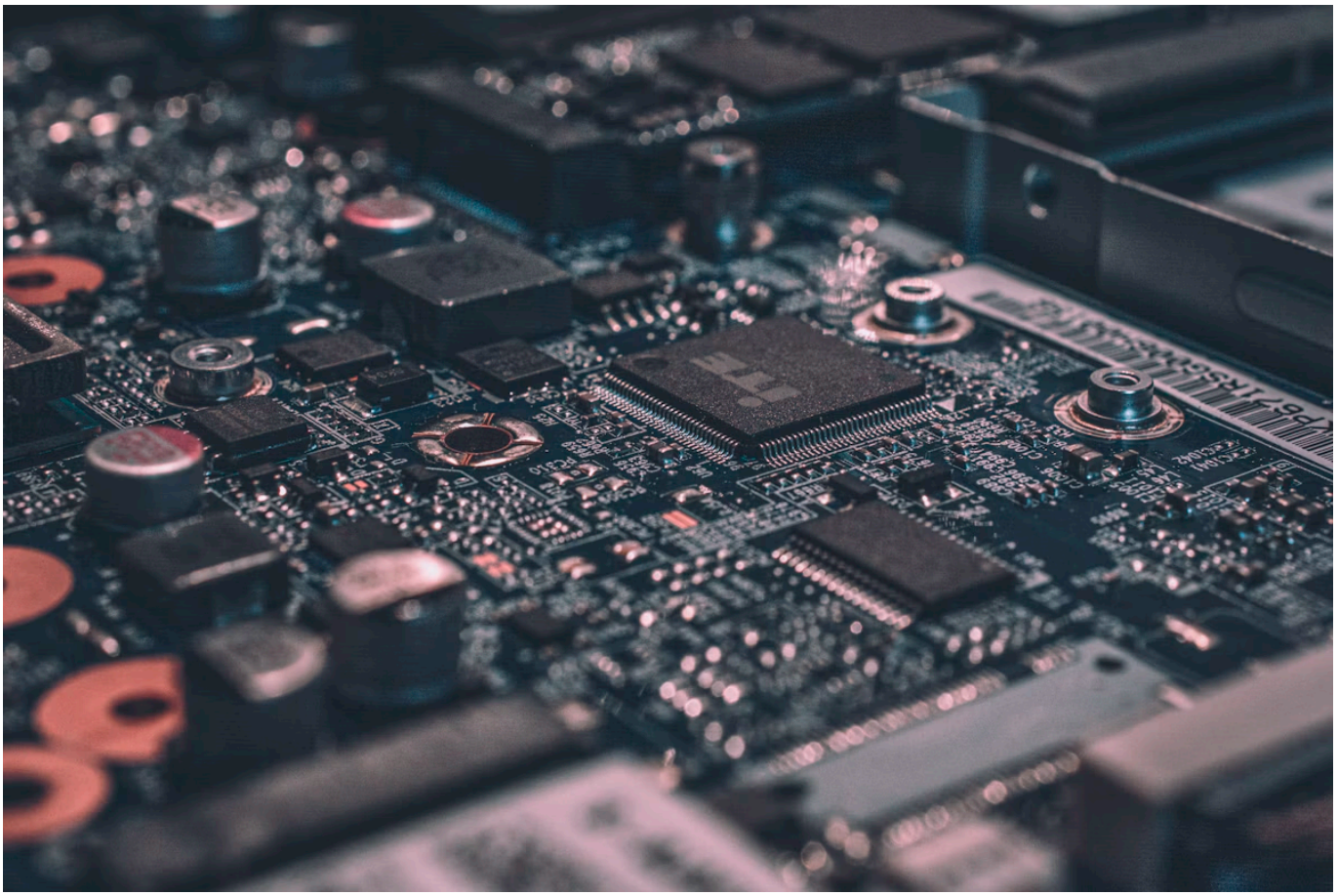
💡 Why do networks matter?

Purpose	Everyday Example
Communication	Sending messages and making video calls
Sharing	Accessing shared files and printers
Information	Browsing websites and searching online
Collaboration	Working on shared documents
Online services	Using cloud applications

> **Remember:** A network is not simply a group of connected devices. It is a system that allows those devices to exchange data using agreed rules.

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02 · Types of Networks



🏠 LAN — Local Area Network

A LAN connects devices within a limited geographical area, such as a home, classroom, office, or computer laboratory.

Example: Computers connected within a university laboratory.

🌍 WAN — Wide Area Network

A WAN connects networks across larger geographical areas, potentially between cities or countries.

Example: A company connecting its offices in Beijing and Shanghai.

LAN vs. WAN

Feature	LAN	WAN
Coverage	Small, limited area	Large geographical area
Example	Home network	Network connecting distant offices
Purpose	Connect nearby devices	Connect separate networks

🔌 Wired vs. Wireless

- **Wired:** Uses physical connections such as Ethernet cables.
- **Wireless:** Uses radio communication technologies such as Wi-Fi.

Wired and wireless describe connection methods, while LAN and WAN describe network scope. They are not opposing categories.

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03 · Meet the Network Devices

🖥️ Network Interface Card (NIC)

A NIC provides a network interface that allows a device to connect to a network.

Think of it as: The device's connection point to the network.

🔀 Switch

A switch connects devices within a local network and forwards Ethernet frames toward the appropriate destination using MAC-address information.

Think of it as: A local traffic director for connected devices.

📡 Router

A router connects different IP networks and forwards packets using destination IP addresses and routing information.

Think of it as: A guide that helps packets move between networks.

📶 Modem

A modem adapts signals for communication over a particular access technology, depending on the type of internet connection.

Think of it as: Equipment that helps establish communication over a service provider's access medium.

Quick Comparison

Device	Main Function
NIC	Provides a network interface
Switch	Forwards frames within a local network
Router	Forwards packets between IP networks
Modem	Adapts signals for an access technology

> **Common mistake:** A switch and a router are not the same. A switch primarily forwards frames within a local network, while a router forwards IP packets between networks.

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04 · IP Addresses vs. MAC Addresses

Devices need addressing information to communicate.

IP Address

An **IP address** is a logical address used at the Internet Protocol layer. Routers use destination IP addresses and routing information to forward packets.

Example: `192.168.1.10`

MAC Address

A **MAC address** is a link-layer address used for local network communication, such as Ethernet frame delivery.

Example: `00:1A:2B:3C:4D:5E`

What's the Difference?

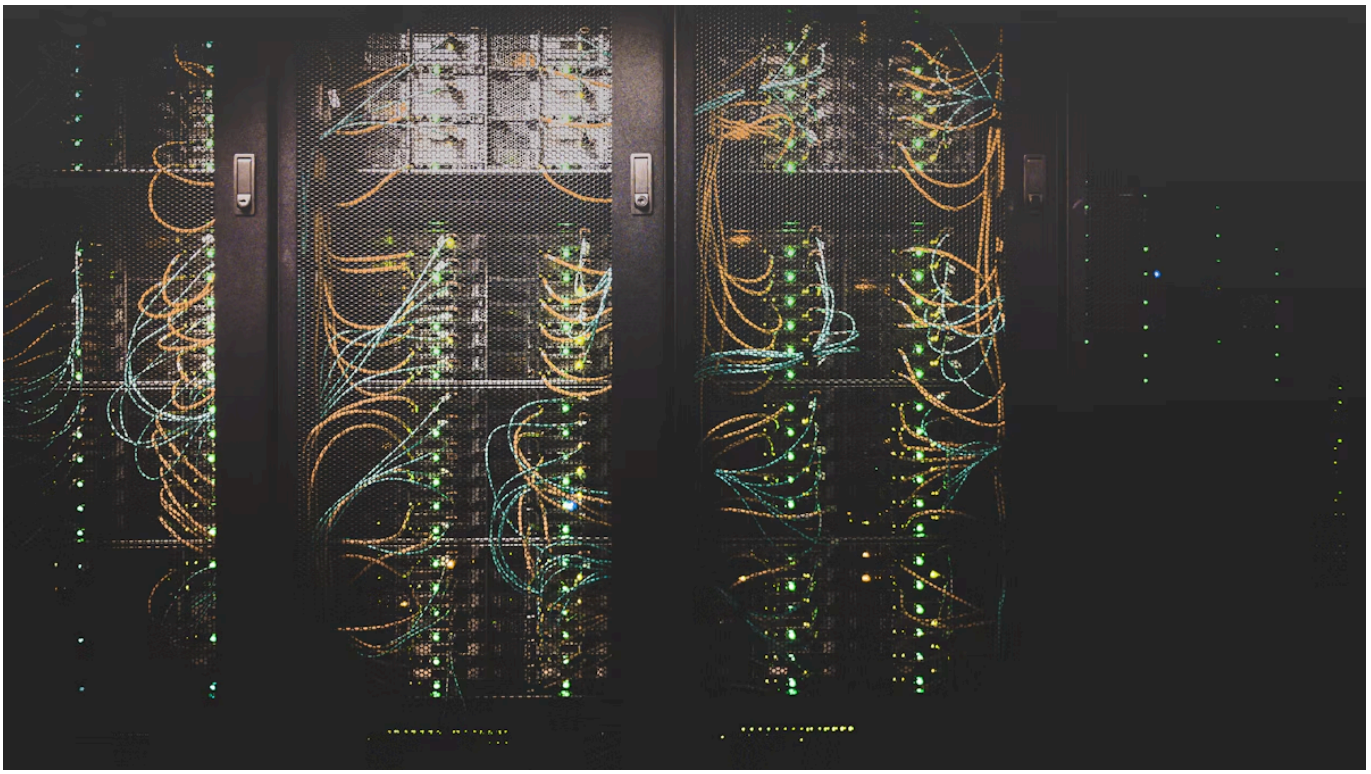
IP Address	MAC Address
Used at the IP layer	Used at the link layer
Helps route packets between networks	Helps deliver frames on a local link
Example: `192.168.1.10`	Example: `00:1A:2B:3C:4D:5E`

> **Key insight:** IP addresses and MAC addresses serve different purposes. They work together rather than replacing each other.

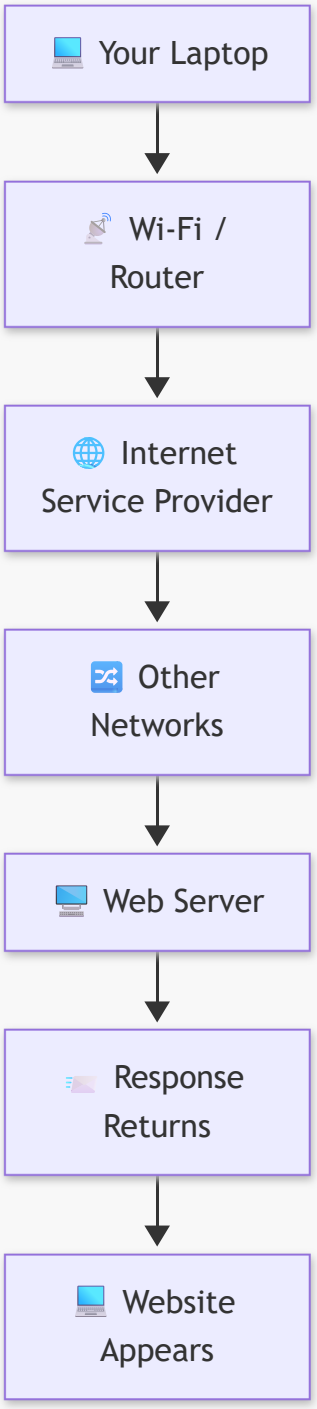
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05 · Follow the Data! 🚀

How does your laptop open a website?



Let's follow a simplified journey.



Step by Step

1. You make a request.

You enter a website address in your browser.

2. Your device finds the destination.

DNS can help resolve the domain name to an IP address.

3. Your request leaves the local network.

If the destination is outside your local IP network, your device typically sends the traffic to its default gateway.

4. Routers forward the packets.

Packets travel through networks toward the web server.

5. The server responds.

The server processes the request and sends the requested data back.

6. Your browser displays the result.

Your browser processes the received data and displays the website.

> **Did you know?** A website request may pass through several routers. The exact path depends on network conditions and routing decisions.

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06 · The Rules Behind Communication

A **network protocol** is a set of rules that governs communication between devices.

Protocol	Main Purpose
IP	Addressing and forwarding packets
TCP	Reliable, ordered byte-stream communication
UDP	Sending datagrams without built-in delivery guarantees
DNS	Retrieving domain-name information
HTTP	Communication between web clients and servers
HTTPS	HTTP communication protected using TLS

Everyday Example

When you visit a website:

1. DNS may help your device find the server's IP address.
2. IP helps deliver packets across networks.
3. TCP or UDP may carry application traffic, depending on the protocol used.
4. HTTP defines the web request and response.
5. HTTPS protects HTTP traffic using TLS.

These protocols perform different jobs and work together to support communication.

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07 · A First Look at Network Security 🔒

Networks must protect connected devices and information.

Basic practices include:

- Use strong, unique passwords.
- Secure Wi-Fi with modern security settings.

- Keep devices and software updated.
- Avoid suspicious links and downloads.
- Use HTTPS when accessing websites.
- Restrict network access to authorized users.

Security is a broad topic. This guide introduces basic awareness rather than advanced configuration.

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08 · Knowledge Check 🧠

Test your understanding before moving on.

Question 1: Which device primarily forwards packets between IP networks?

A. Switch
B. Router
C. Keyboard
D. Monitor

Question 2: Which network usually covers a home or classroom?

A. WAN
B. Satellite
C. LAN
D. The entire Internet

Question 3: What does DNS help a device do?

A. Find records associated with a domain name
B. Replace the router
C. Increase CPU speed
D. Connect a monitor

Question 4: What is the main role of a switch?

A. Display web pages
B. Store passwords
C. Replace every network protocol
D. Forward frames within a local network

Question 5: Which statement is correct?

A. IP and MAC addresses are interchangeable.
B. IP and MAC addresses have different roles.
C. Only routers need addresses.
D. DNS is a physical network device.

Short-Answer Challenge

1. Explain the difference between a LAN and a WAN.
2. Describe one difference between a router and a switch.

3. Explain how a laptop can access a website through a home network.

▶ **Show the answer key**

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09 · Key Takeaways

Before you finish, make sure you can explain these ideas:

- **Networks connect devices** so they can communicate and share resources.
- **LAN and WAN** describe the geographical scope of a network.
- **Switches and routers** perform different forwarding functions.
- **IP and MAC addresses** serve different addressing purposes.
- **Protocols** define how data is exchanged.
- **Network security** helps protect devices and information.

The big picture: computer networking allows devices around the world to communicate through addressing, protocols, and interconnected networks.

📖 References

Use these resources to verify and deepen your understanding:

1. Cisco Networking Academy
2. Cloudflare Learning Center — Computer Networks
3. Cloudflare Learning Center — DNS
4. MDN Web Docs — An Overview of HTTP

Record the sources you actually consult and verify before submitting the final version.